Dax Mikow

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Education

- **University of Maryland, Baltimore County** — Baltimore, Maryland
  *Bachelor of Computer Science, GPA: **4.0**, Honors College, Expected Graduation May 2028.* — *Aug 2024 - Present*

Experience

- **Imaging Research Center** — Baltimore, Maryland
  Software Developer — *May 2025 - August 2026*
  - **Development**: Built interactive applications in **Unity and Unreal Engine** as part of a small research team.
  - **Legacy Modernization**: **Recovered and upgraded** legacy Unity projects, rewriting editor-only data systems to run in deployable builds.
  - **Artistic Integration**: Turned artists' **creative goals into working software**, collaborating closely with a **multidisciplinary team** of artists, scientists, and engineers.
  - **UX Focus**: **Iterated on UX** so exhibits met accessibility standards and were usable in public showcase settings.
  - **Project: DeepStar AR**: Ported Lisa Moren's Deep Star video installation to **augmented reality** as solo developer; **exhibited at UMBC's CADVC gallery** in February 2026.
  - **Project: iHarp Polar Ice Cave**: Built **procedural UI animations** and gave UX feedback on the VR climate quiz for an Unreal Engine 5 museum installation about polar ice loss.
  - **Project: REVLR**: Updated old systems to create **responsive navigation tooling** for a VR environment while **reducing motion sickness** in users.
- **UMBC Game Developers Club** — Baltimore, Maryland
  President — *May 2026 - Present*
  - **Leadership**: Lead the UMBC Game Developers Club, from setting its **long-term direction** to running **day-to-day operations**.
  - **Event Planning**: Plan and run **large club events** from first idea through execution.
  - **University Relations**: Work with university to **secure funding**, meeting spaces, and resources for members.
  - **Industry Outreach**: Build **relationships with game industry professionals** and bring them in as speakers and guests at club events.
  - **Team Management**: Coordinate the officer team so responsibilities are clear and tasks see completion.

Projects

- **The Last Stop** — Baltimore, Maryland
  Lead Developer, Graphics Programmer — *Dec 2025 - May 2026*
  - **Overview**: Led programming on a **15-person team**, across multiple disciplines, for a narrative puzzle game shipped on Windows and Linux with about **30 minutes of finished gameplay**.
  - **Puzzle Architecture**: Built the game's **core puzzle system**, including the interactive table, the placeable track tiles, and an **editor-only tool** designers used to build puzzles.
  - **Graphics**: Wrote **custom shaders** for stylized water, clouds and the skybox, plus a screen-wide quantization and posterization filter to achieve a **unique, distinct visual style**.
  - **Workflow**: Worked in **agile sprints** through several rounds of **public playtesting**, using **player feedback** to move from a **minimum viable product to a polished release**.
  - **Results**: Tied for **1st place** at the 2026 IGDA Student Capstone Showcase despite not being a capstone project.
- **Affliction** — Baltimore, Maryland
  Technical Artist, Visual Effect Developer, Graphics Programmer — *Oct 2026*
  - **Technical Art**: Created **unique visual effects** to achieve **atmospheric polish** and integrate with technology.
  - **Workflow**: Worked on a **team of industry professionals**. Did **daily syncs** and **Kanban** project tracking.

Programming Skills

- **Languages**: C#, C++, HLSL/GLSL, Java, C
- **Technologies**: Unity, Unreal, Git, Github, Jira, Linux